

Testimony of David Kushner (Philadelphia Regional Hearing)

I appreciate and value the opportunity to testify and share my thoughts on this important issue that has a true and lasting impact on our community, neighborhood, and region.

I recognize that the issue of redistricting does not come up frequently and is oftentimes politically motivated and divided on partisan political lines. However, that is not the nature of my opposition or the basis of my testimony.

My concern and comments come exclusively out of concerns for the future of this community, the need for a unified voice, and how, we the people of NE Philadelphia, can be best and most appropriately represented within the scope of the representation that the results of redistricting define.

As a longtime community activist involved for over 25 years in civic and faith based activities in the region - I feel I have a unique perspective on the needs of our communities and the mindset of the many residents of our community. As a lifelong resident of NE Philadelphia, a parent raising our 3 children in NE Philadelphia, chaplain for numerous law enforcement agencies, a founding (and still active) member of the mayor's commission on faith based and interfaith affairs, a PDAC member, a former committee person, and more - I can attest firsthand that the pride and cohesiveness of NE residents across the spectrums of age, race, religion, and socio economic classes throughout the NE is strong.

We all have a shared and joint respect for the past, interest in the present, and concern for the future. We may have some differences - but, as the saying goes: There is far more that unites us than divides us. The deep concern for the current redistricting plan, and the way it would break up the unity of NE Philadelphia representation is one of the many issues that unites us.

I have had a very positive relationship with the members of Congress and their dedicated staffs that have represented this area for quite some time, going back to Congress Members Borski, Hoeffel, Schwartz, and Boyle.

In addition to my communal involvement which i touched on previously, professionally i oversee the office of government relations for a nonprofit social service agency focused on victims of sexual abuse and those suffering from substance abuse, addiction, and various mental health crisis situations.

I can say first hand, based upon a great deal of communal and professional experiences - that the plan before you today will dramatically result in the underrepresentation of this community, will dramatically lower the levels of constituent services available to the residents of this community, and will smother the voices of the children, seniors, and various other unique populations that make up the incredibly diverse constituency within the confines of NE Philadelphia

I stand in strong opposition to the current redistricting plan and urge all who have a say on this matter, to please stand and speak in unity with the residents of NE Philadelphia by supporting a redistricting plan that helps keep our community representation intact and helps ensure that we, as a diverse and unified community have appropriate representation in Government.